

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 442

By Pody

A RESOLUTION to honor and welcome Swami Brahnaviharidas, learned swami of the BAPS Swaminarayan Sanstha.

WHEREAS, we are pleased to specially recognize those eminent spiritual leaders who travel to our great State to foster goodwill and develop common bonds of fellowship; and

WHEREAS, Swami Brahnaviharidas is one such estimable person, who evinces the greatest integrity and probity in all his chosen endeavors; and

WHEREAS, Swami Brahnaviharidas is respected globally as a learned swami of the BAPS Swaminarayan Sanstha; he grew up and was educated in the United Kingdom and was initiated as a Swami by His Holiness Pramukh Swami Maharaj in 1981; and

WHEREAS, Swami Brahnaviharidas is known across the world as an inspiring leader, a creative thinker, a motivational speaker, and a relentless champion of humanitarian causes. He is a thought leader and part of the creative team for numerous projects of international repute, such as the Swaminarayan Akshardham, Neasden Mandir, international festivals such as the Pramukh Swami Maharaj Centennial Celebrations, and at present the BAPS Hindu Mandir, Abu Dhabi, Dubai, UAE; and

WHEREAS, through the generosity of the Ruler of Abu Dhabi, HH Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, and the long-standing relationship with the Prime Minister of India, Shri Narendra Modi, Swami Brahnaviharidas has led the creation of the recently inaugurated first traditional stone Hindu Mandir in the Middle East in Abu Dhabi; and

WHEREAS, Swami Brahnaviharidas oversees the global outreach work of BAPS and in that capacity has created and nurtured relationships with various Heads of State and prominent

leaders from around the world, sharing with them the traditions and ancient architecture of India and promoting the Hindu spiritual messages of faith, devotion, and harmony; and

WHEREAS, through witnessing his guru Pramukh Swami Maharaj's genuine respect for all religions, Swami Brahnaviharidas has furthered BAPS's intra and interfaith work. He strives to foster meaningful relationships with various Hindu swamis and gurus to nurture greater unity across the constellation of Hindu traditions; and

WHEREAS, he is regularly invited to represent Hinduism and speak at global interfaith conferences around the world, such as the Global Interfaith Summit at Dubai EXPO 2020, the European Union-Bahrain Conference on Freedom of Religion and Belief, the Historic First Interfaith Conference in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia, and the recent International Religious Leaders Conference held in Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia; and

WHEREAS, his deep intent for cross-cultural harmony, knowledge of Hindu scriptures, saintliness, and logic have enabled him to meaningfully discuss current affairs and global challenges faced by different faiths to ultimately focus upon peaceful coexistence; and

WHEREAS, Swami Brahnaviharidas has inspired leaders, medical professionals, journalists, politicians, and students through his insightful and relatable talks infused by his deep study of global cultures, histories, and philosophies. He has also personally counseled and guided many around the world, and his advice, wisdom, and genuine care have helped thousands; for his many achievements and spiritual and social service, he has been awarded an honorary PhD from Gujarat University; and

WHEREAS, during the devastating Gujarat earthquake in 2001, he coordinated a team of 6,500 volunteers in BAPS's rescue, relief, and rehabilitation effort where millions were fed, fifteen villages were reconstructed, and 4,500 homes were rebuilt; following the devastating tsunami in December 2004, he coordinated the BAPS relief effort alongside 2000 volunteers; and

WHEREAS, during the COVID-19 pandemic, he was called upon by the government of India to help with the relief operations. This included sourcing and transporting over 50,000 cylinders of medical oxygen to India from Abu Dhabi during the devastating second wave; and

WHEREAS, during the ongoing Russia and Ukraine war, the Prime Minister of India, Shri Narendra Modi, called upon Swami Brahmaviharidas to deploy BAPS volunteers to set up a camp on the Polish/Ukraine border for the safe evacuation of Indian nationals, students, and citizens from Ukraine; and

WHEREAS, under the guidance of Mahant Swami Maharaj and Senior Sadhus, he helps oversee devotional, cultural, humanitarian, and spiritual activities of BAPS; and

WHEREAS, this inspirational, international leader is most worthy of our approbation and recognition on this special occasion; now, therefore;

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we extend our most cordial welcome to Swami Brahmaviharidas and offer him our best wishes for an enjoyable, fruitful, and rewarding visit to the State of Tennessee.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.